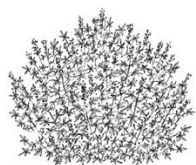


Reproductive & Menstrual Problems



Chaste Tree
(*Vitex agnus-castus*)

Women have always tended to use herbal medicine more than men, traditionally in their role as healers in the home and now, in part, due to the proven effects of many herbs on the reproductive system. Herbs such as wild yam contain constituents similar to the female sex hormones, estrogen and progesterone, which can help regulate the menstrual cycle, increase or decrease fertility, and support the body through menopause. Common menstrual problems, such as cramps, premenstrual syndrome, and heavy bleeding, respond well to self-treatment. However, chronic conditions or infertility in either women or men require professional attention.

⚠ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Severe pain in the abdomen or pelvis
- Significant or sudden change in menstruation, such as prolonged, heavy, or irregular periods

Important Note

For the best treatment, consult an herbalist. Seek professional advice before taking a remedy if you believe that you may be pregnant. See *Pregnancy*, p. 317.

🌿 Menstrual Problems

The menstrual cycle can be disturbed for many reasons, most of them relating to hormonal imbalances. Other causes include stress, too much or too little exercise, weight problems, food sensitivity or allergy, steroids, the contraceptive pill, chronic illness, vitamin and mineral deficiency, and even excess caffeine, alcohol, or smoking. To determine the underlying cause, it is important to consult a professional practitioner.

Taking remedies for menstrual problems.

The remedies listed should all be taken at the appropriate point in the cycle for 2–3 cycles.

The normal menstrual cycle lasts about 28 days. If this cycle varies greatly from one period to another without reason, it could be termed irregular.

Premenstrual syndrome (PMS) and period pain have many causes and are experienced at some stage by most women. Breast tenderness, sore nipples, and fluid retention are common symptoms.

Heavy periods can result in anemia. If your period lasts longer than 5 days or if you have to change your protection every 2 hours, your periods may be too heavy. Nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146) is an excellent tonic, especially for heavy bleeding, as it contains more iron than spinach and can be eaten as a nourishing vegetable.

Self-help

Combine herbal remedies with a diet high in fresh vegetables and fruit, and low in fatty foods, sugar, and alcohol. Try not to smoke. Regular exercise, particularly of the waist and pelvis, is helpful, as is a relaxed attitude to life. All reproductive problems will benefit from this simple approach.

⚠ **General caution** For any chronic menstrual problem, it is wise to seek professional attention, especially if your periods are very heavy or painful.

Irregular Cycle

Herb Chaste tree (*Vitex agnus-castus*, p. 151)

Remedy Take tablets, or take 30–40 drops (1.5–2 ml) of tincture with water each morning on waking for at least 2 months.

Herb Motherwort (*Leonurus cardiaca*, p. 227)

Remedy Make an infusion and take $\frac{3}{4}$ –1 $\frac{1}{4}$ cups (150–300 ml) a day for up to 3 monthly cycles.

Caution Do not take if menstrual bleeding is heavy.

Premenstrual Syndrome

Herbs Vervain (*Verbena officinalis*, p. 149), linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277)

Remedy (Internal) Make an infusion using either herb (or an equal mix of both) and drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) throughout the day.

Herb Valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148)

Remedy (Internal) Take tablets containing valerian, or take 20–40 drops of tincture with water up to 5 times a day.

Herb Rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128)

Remedy (External) Make an infusion with 1 tbsp of dried or 2 tbsp of fresh leaves to 1 quart (liter) of water and strain into a warm bath each morning. Alternatively, add 5–10 drops of essential oil to a bath.

Note Also try the chaste tree remedy under Irregular Cycle above.

Breast Tenderness & Sore Nipples

Herb German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77)

Remedy Make a compress with an infusion of 50 g of herb and 1 cup (250 ml) of water. Place gently over the breasts. Repeat as often as required to achieve relief.

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Apply ointment to the nipples. If breastfeeding, wipe off the ointment before feeding.

Fluid Retention

Herb Dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141)

Remedy Make an infusion with the leaves and drink up to 1 $\frac{3}{4}$ cups (450 ml) a day.

Heavy Menstrual Bleeding

Herb Chuang xiong (*Ligusticum wallachii*), white peony (*Paeonia lactiflora*, p. 117), dong quai (*Angelica sinensis*, p. 63), rehmannia (*Rehmannia glutinosa*, p. 125)

Remedy Mix equal parts of each root and make a decoction using 15 g of the mixture to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Drink in 3 equal doses throughout the day.

Note Any of these herbs will help, but they are best together, in which form they are known as *Four Things Soup*.

Herb Shepherd's purse (*Capsella bursa-pastoris*, p. 183), nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146)

Remedy Make an infusion using 7.5 g of each herb (or 15 g of shepherd's purse only) to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Divide into 3–4 doses and drink throughout the day.

Period Pain

Flavor the decoctions with 1 heaping tsp of caraway seeds (*Carum carvi*, p. 184). Mix before decocting.

Herbs Wild yam (*Dioscorea villosa*, p. 91), cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150), black haw (*Viburnum prunifolium*, p. 281)

Remedy Make a decoction using 15 g of herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Sip small amounts during the day; or take 2 tsp of tincture with water 3–4 times a day for up to 3 days, then reduce the dose to 1 tsp a day for 5 days, or take tablets.

Herb White peony (*Paeonia lactiflora*, p. 117)

Remedy Make a decoction using 20 g of root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Sip this throughout the day.